Most AI tools flatten *qual* into vibes.

A field note on rigour, structure, and what AI still gets wrong.

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What "*qual analysis*" actually means

Qualitative analysis is how researchers make sense of **unstructured text** — interviews, focus groups, open-ended survey responses, online discussions.

The goal: *turn messy human language into patterns you can trust and act on.*

What goes wrong by default

Paste unstructured data into a generic chatbot and you get a tidy-looking summary back.

But that summary is a **dead end**. You can’t trace where it came from, you can’t audit it, and you can’t feed it into the next step of real analysis.

It looks clean. ***It isn’t useful.***

Real qual follows a *method*

Researchers don't just "read and summarise." They follow established practices like **grounded theory** and **Braun & Clarke thematic analysis** — decades-old methods designed to keep findings honest.

Code → **Theme** → **Pattern** → **Cross-case**

Skip a step — the findings collapse.

STEP 01

Coding and grouping

Coding means tagging every small chunk of text with what it's about, using a structure like **DOMAIN/CATEGORY/SUBCATEGORY**.

Similar codes then group into **themes** — each with a clear boundary of what it covers and what it leaves out.

✔ *"Describes pricing as confusing"*

✕ *"Frustrated with pricing" — that's a guess*

STEP 02

Patterns and cross-checks

Six lenses to read the data through:

- **01 Similarity**
- **02 Difference**
- **03 Frequency**
- **04 Sequence**
- **05 Co-occur**
- **06 Cause**

Every “X causes Y” claim is labelled — did the participant **say it**, or did the analyst **guess it**? That single distinction separates research from storytelling.

Where most GenAI Analysis *break*

- **Quotes aren't verified** *against the original text*
- **No confidence levels** *on any finding*
- **Outliers get ignored** *that doesn't fit the pattern*
- **No traceability** *from theme back*

If you can't audit it, you shouldn't trust it.

Built a *claude skill* that does this properly

It runs the full method: **coding, themes, quotes, six pattern checks, quality flags.**

The output isn't a written summary. It's **structured data** — every finding traceable back to the exact line a participant said it.

Why structured output, not a report?

Because the analysis is the ***raw material***, not the finished thing.

Take the structured output and write the report yourself. Or hand it to **another AI layer** to draft the review, the deck, the executive summary.

One rigorous pass. Many downstream uses.

Try it. Break it. Tell me.

It's free on my GitHub.

Download and load in your Claude Skills. Drop in interviews, focus groups, or open-ended survey responses and see what comes back.

*Where do **you** think AI still falls short on qualitative work?*

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